aesthetic line . . ."

I parodied this with a poem I called "The Foundation of S.F. Success/' which began, "If you ask me how to shine in the science-fiction line . . ."

It was a parody of myself and of the Foundation series, in which I openly admitted my debt to Roman history in the second verse, which goes:

"So success is not a mystery, just brush up on your history, and borrow

day by day. "Take an Empire that was Roman and you'll find it is at home in all

the starry Milky Way. "With a drive that's hyperspatial, through the parsecs you will race,

you'll find that plotting is a breeze, "With a tiny bit of cribbin' from the works of Edward Gibbon, and

that Greek, Thucydides."

F & SF occasionally published poetry, and it was Tony Boucher who bought the parody. He was delighted and wrote to tell me he thought it the cleverest bit of self-parody since Swinburne. He paid me $15 for it—not much, but it was the first poetry I'd ever sold.

To be sure, it was not really poetry, but only comic verse; but then, comic verse is the limit of my poetic muse. Fortunate is the man who knows his own limitations.

At the moment, in fact, I was but too aware of my own limitations and was quite convinced I had risen to the highest level made possible by them.

The year was 1954.1 was thirty-four years old. And . . .

As far as my chemical career was concerned, I had gone as far as I could. I had my doctorate, I had my professorial status. I might achieve another trivial promotion or two, but I could not honestly expect that I would ever be a great biochemistry teacher outside my own immediate classroom. The absolute failure of the textbook had made that plain.

As to my other career, science fiction, there, too, I had gone as far as I could. I